

THE EMPLOYMENT ASSUMPTION

Why ADAP's Core Premise Fails Its Own Evidence Test — Plain Language Edition

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown • April 2026 • Free to Share

What this document is about

The Alberta government says ADAP is designed for people with disabilities who are able to work. This document shows, using the government's own numbers and words, that this premise does not hold up. It is not an opinion. It is a comparison of what the government has said against what the government's own data shows.

THE NUMBERS — FROM THE GOVERNMENT'S OWN DATA

83.9%

of AISH recipients have zero
employment income

Gov't of Alberta Open Data, Sept 2025

79,290

Albertans on AISH as of
September 2025

Gov't of Alberta Open Data, Sept 2025

16.1%

have any employment or
self-employment income

Gov't of Alberta Open Data, Sept 2025

That means roughly 66,000 of the 79,290 people currently on AISH earn nothing from employment. Not because they are lazy. Not because they have not tried. But because AISH eligibility itself requires that your disability permanently and substantially prevents you from earning a living. That is the government's own definition.

"For a person with a disability to be eligible for AISH, they must have a mental or physical impairment that causes substantial limitation in their ability to earn a livelihood and is likely to affect them permanently."

— Government of Alberta — AISH Eligibility Definition

THE CONTRADICTION

AISH says: you qualify if your disability permanently prevents you from earning a living. ADAP says: you are being moved to an employment program because you can work. These two statements cannot both be true at the same time for the same people.

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT SAYS

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT'S OWN DATA SHOWS

ADAP is designed for Albertans with disabilities who are able to work and want to pursue employment.

83.9% of AISH recipients currently earn zero employment income. AISH eligibility requires that the disability permanently limits the ability to earn a living.

"The government has failed to explain how the situation of people with disabilities has suddenly changed to allow most of those on AISH to work."

— Friends of Medicare, September 2025

THE LABOUR MARKET REALITY

Even if every AISH recipient wanted to work — and many do — the labour market is not waiting for them.

- Alberta is currently experiencing some of its highest youth and general unemployment rates in years.
- Employers are not legally required under current federal law to hire people with disabilities — only to accommodate those already employed.
- The Alberta Human Rights Commission's own guidance states that an employer cannot be expected to place someone with uncontrolled seizures on a scaffold or in a truck. Many AISH recipients have conditions far more complex than this.
- ADAP includes resume help and mock interviews. It does not include a labour market that will hire 66,000 people with severe and permanent disabilities.

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT STILL HAS NOT TOLD YOU

As of April 2026 — 82 days before the July 1 transition — the government has not published:

- The detailed medical criteria that will determine who is assessed as employable under ADAP.
- The specific assessment tool or process that will be used.
- How episodic disabilities — conditions that fluctuate — will be assessed.
- What happens if someone is assessed as employable but cannot find or sustain employment.
- How the assessment will account for disabilities that are invisible or difficult to document.

A program built on an employment assumption — without published employment assessment criteria — is asking 79,290 people to accept a transition without knowing the rules.

IT ALSO COSTS MORE

\$46.8M Cost to administer AISH in 2025-26 <i>Alberta Budget 2026</i>	\$88.4M Cost to administer ADAP in 2026-27 <i>Alberta Budget 2026</i>	+\$41.6M Additional admin cost — despite lower benefits <i>Alberta Budget 2026</i>
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The program pays recipients less. It costs taxpayers more to run. This is not fiscal responsibility. This is fiscal contradiction.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The government's own data shows that 83.9% of AISH recipients earn nothing from employment — because the program's own eligibility criteria requires that their disability permanently prevents them from doing so. ADAP is built on the assumption that most of these same people can work. The government has not explained this contradiction. It has not published the assessment criteria. It costs \$41.6 million more to administer than the program it replaces. And it launches in 82 days.

This is not a policy disagreement. It is a measurable, documented, internally contradictory program being imposed on Alberta's most vulnerable residents without adequate justification.

SOURCES

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